

A Safer XPerience

Microsoft's celebrated and trusted Windows XP OS is vulnerable to security threats. The operating system has a huge number of loopholes—and these chinks invite a host of virus attacks.

This is where Windows XP Service Pack 2 (SP2) steps in. SP2 is Microsoft's attempt at plugging this set of loopholes—it is Microsoft's damage control effort at fortifying XP's defences.

Here's a walkthrough of the installation and configuration of SP2.

Installation

Installing SP2 can be tedious. Depending on how often you have been updating the OS, you may have to install anywhere between 80 and 270 MB of updates.

If you are installing SP2 on a laptop, which is quite a lengthy process, you had better run your machine on AC power.

Security Center

Once you have installed SP2, you are asked to reboot, following which a message asks you if you want to turn the Automatic Update on or off. The Security Center offers three options—

Firewall, Automatic Update and Virus Protection. The Virus Protection option is displayed alongside the anti-virus software already installed on the system. Similarly, if you have installed a third-party firewall, the Firewall option shows alongside the customary Windows Firewall.

Windows Firewall

The Internet Connection Firewall (ICF) that came with the earlier version of Windows XP was inadequate, and was disabled by default. Consequently, a whopping number of computers with XP were paralysed by high impact worms such as Sasser and Nimda. With SP2, the firewall is enabled by default. The firewall's Stateful Packet Inspection (SPI) feature monitors the computer during booting. It meticulously checks incoming data packets against requested outgoing data packets. If the SPI comes across a suspicious data packet that does not match the request criteria, it simply rejects it. This tackles malicious programs when the system starts. Once the OS initialises, the Windows



The virus protection tab displays information such as the name of anti-virus software installed and its status

Firewall's run-time policy takes over.

However, the Windows Firewall still isn't as sturdy as third-party solutions. Most firewall solutions, available for free on the Internet, are much better equipped to handle serious attacks.

Internet Explorer

SP2 comes with a pop-up blocker for IE. It's in the form of an info bar on top of the page, and offers options such as temporarily allowing pop-ups. You can also manage IE add-ons in SP2. It comes as a special feature that can be found in the Tools menu. You can view the add-ons currently installed on the system, enable or disable them, and even update ActiveX control for the plugins.

Another option lets you view disabled add-ons with digital signatures from unknown publishers. However, one big hitch that actually throws open the system to possible virus threats is that you can only enable and disable add-ons for IE, but no other browser.

Outlook Express

Outlook Express has always been vulnerable to e-mails with malicious attachments. SP2 now makes Outlook Express much safer. Now Outlook Express will not directly display images. Instead, it asks you whether

you want to download the images to view them.

A Final Word

With the current security issues we all face, installing SP2 is not really an option—it is a necessity. Dial-up users need not fret—Microsoft will shortly start shipping a free CD to all authorised Windows users. You can also get SP2 from the DVD and the CD with this issue of *Digit*.

Apart from security patching, SP2 also includes useful features such as DirectX9.0b and Bluetooth support, and an update for Windows Media Player 9.

It even has features that ease out WiFi settings on your machine. We can't say for sure whether SP2 will stand the test of time, but it is a step in the right direction. ☐

Problem Areas

The following programs are known to experience a loss of functionality when they run on a Windows XP Service Pack 2-based computer: Norton AntiVirus, OmniPage Pro, Outpost Firewall, ZoneAlarm, Yahoo! Messenger, and Virtual PC. For the complete list, visit <http://support.microsoft.com/default.aspx?kbid=884130&product=windowsxpsp2>



Security Center comes up after installation, and you can manage various settings from here